

DIGITALAIKART ORIGINAL

THE CIBIL SCORE & LOAN APPROVAL PLAYBOOK

India 2026-27 Edition

Fix your credit score. Understand what banks
actually check. Get your next loan approved.

RBI 2025 RULES DECODED

THE Rs. 100/DAY DISPUTE RIGHT

THE 90-DAY REPAIR PLAN

FOIR MATHS, WORKED

Verified against the Reserve Bank of India's
Credit Information Reporting Directions, 2025 and the
Credit Information Companies Directions, 2025 (updated 1 July 2026)

October 2026 | Digitalaikart

How to use this playbook

This is a working manual, not a lecture. Read the path that matches your situation, then act on the checklist at the end of that path. Everything here is built on the Reserve Bank of India's own rules and the published rules of the four credit bureaus, current as of October 2026.

- **Your score is below 700 and you were rejected:** start with Chapters 5, 6 and 7 to find and fix the damage, then run the 90-day repair plan in Chapter 15.
- **You are applying for a loan or card in the next 1-3 months:** read Chapter 4 (the new reporting cycle), Chapter 8 (the utilisation timing hack), Chapter 12 (what banks check beyond the score) and Chapter 13 (the FOIR maths).
- **You are a first-time borrower with no credit history:** go straight to Chapter 10, then Chapter 14 to see what you realistically qualify for.
- **You just want the facts fast:** the Quick Reference in Chapter 20 has every rule, date and contact on one page.

A plain-language disclaimer

This playbook is educational and is not financial, legal or investment advice. It explains published RBI rules and standard lender practice. Every figure and rule was checked against official sources in October 2026 and is correct at the time of writing, but rules change and lenders set their own internal policies. Interest-rate and interest-cost figures used in examples are clearly marked as illustrations. Before acting on anything here, confirm the current position with your bank or the relevant credit bureau. You are responsible for your own financial decisions.

Contents

1. Your score is the most expensive three-digit number you own
2. The four bureaus and your free full credit report
3. What actually builds your score - and what does not
4. The 2026 reporting revolution: why your score moves in days now
5. The five score killers, and the exact fix for each
6. Read your credit report line by line
7. The dispute playbook: fix errors and get paid for delays
8. The utilisation timing hack
9. Recovering from settled, written-off or default
10. First-time borrowers and thin files
11. Credit cards: how to use one without hurting your score
12. What banks check beyond your score
13. How a lender actually decides
14. The FOIR maths, worked

15. Score bands: what you qualify for
16. The 90-day repair plan
17. The 12-month rebuild plan for scores below 650
18. Which debt to clear first
19. Your score is a savings problem too
20. Comparing loan offers: the numbers that actually matter
21. Co-applicants, guarantors and joint loans
22. Your rights as a borrower
23. Credit after a job loss or restructuring
24. Credit for students, young earners and small business
25. Five real profiles, worked end to end
26. The habits of people who never worry about their score
27. Scams, myths and traps
28. Questions people ask most
29. Worksheets, templates and trackers
30. Quick reference, contacts and glossary
31. The one-page action plan and tracker

Sources: Reserve Bank of India Master Direction - Credit Information Reporting Directions, 2025 (6 January 2025); RBI (Credit Information Companies) Directions, 2025 (28 November 2025, updated 1 July 2026); RBI amendment directions on reporting frequency (4 December 2025); RBI framework for compensation for delayed updation / rectification of credit information (26 October 2023, effective 26 April 2024); TransUnion CIBIL and CRIF High Mark published guidance; and reported coverage in The Times of India, Moneycontrol, Outlook Money, Mint and The Economic Times.

Chapter 1

Your score is the most expensive three-digit number you own

A three-digit number between 300 and 900 quietly decides whether you get a home, a car, a business loan or a credit card - and how much you pay for the privilege. Most people only look at it after a rejection. The people who fix it look at it before they apply.

Your CIBIL score is a summary of how you have handled borrowed money. It is calculated by TransUnion CIBIL, one of India's four licensed credit bureaus, from data that banks and lenders send them about your loans and credit cards. The number itself is not a judgement of your income, your savings or your character. It is a prediction of one thing: how likely you are to repay on time.

The money at stake is not small

A higher score does not just get you approved - it gets you a cheaper loan. Lenders price risk: a borrower they trust pays a lower interest rate than one they do not. On a Rs. 50 lakh home loan over 20 years, the difference between an 8.5% rate and a 9.5% rate is roughly **Rs. 7.7 lakh in extra interest** (an illustration based on a standard EMI calculation, not a quote from any lender). That single number is why this playbook exists.

Where your score is used

- Home loans, car loans, personal loans, education loans, gold loans and business loans.
- Credit cards - approval, and the credit limit you are offered.
- Some landlords, employers in the financial sector, and telecom or utility providers now run checks too.
- Loan-against-property and top-up loans, where the bank re-checks your behaviour even on a secured product.

Myth to drop right now

There is no RBI-mandated minimum score. The Reserve Bank of India does not fix a cut-off at which banks must approve or reject you. Each lender sets its own internal threshold. What RBI does mandate is that lenders must tell you the specific reason for a rejection - a vague 'not approved' is no longer compliant.

Chapter 2

The four bureaus and your free full credit report

You have a legal right to see your own credit file for free, once a year, from every bureau. Most people never use it - which is exactly why errors sit on reports for years.

India has four credit information companies (CICs) licensed by the RBI: TransUnion CIBIL, Experian, Equifax and CRIF High Mark. Different lenders report to and read from different bureaus, so your file is not identical across all four. A closed loan may still show as 'active' at one bureau and correctly closed at another.

Your free full credit report (FFCR)

Under the RBI's Credit Information Reporting Directions, 2025, every bureau must give you one **free full credit report, including your credit score**, once in a calendar year (January to December), electronically, after you authenticate. This is per bureau - so if you use all four, you get up to four free full reports a year. The link to access it must sit on the bureau's homepage.

The 'free score' apps are a different thing. Apps such as Paisabazaar, Google Pay and Moneyview show a score refreshed roughly monthly. That is a commercial arrangement, not an RBI right. Use the official full report when you need to audit or dispute; use an app for a quick monthly glance.

Soft enquiry vs hard enquiry - the difference that matters

Type of check	Who does it	Effect on your score
Soft enquiry	You, checking your own score or report	None at all. You can check as often as you like.
Hard enquiry	A lender pulling your report because you applied for credit	Can dip your score slightly and temporarily; several in a short window look risky.

What your report actually contains

- **Personal and contact information:** name, PAN, date of birth, addresses, phone and email.
- **Employment information:** what your lender has on file.
- **Account information:** every loan and card, its status, your payment history, days past due (DPD), outstanding balance, credit limit and the amount you have ever used (high credit).
- **Enquiry information:** every lender that has pulled your report, and when.

Chapter 3

What actually builds your score - and what does not

CIBIL looks at five things. You cannot game them, but you can shape them, and two of them do most of the work.

The five factors CIBIL weighs are payment history, credit utilisation, credit mix, the length of your credit history, and new credit enquiries. CIBIL does not publish the exact weights - the scoring model is proprietary, so any precise percentage you see online is an industry estimate, not an official figure. Treat the order below as the reliable part: payment behaviour first, utilisation second, everything else after.

Factor	What it measures	The fastest lever
Payment history	Whether you pay EMIs and card bills on time	Never miss a due date. Set auto-pay.
Credit utilisation	How much of your available limit you use	Keep it under 30%; aim under 10% before a loan.
Credit mix	A healthy blend of secured and unsecured credit	Add one EMI product if you only have cards.
Length of history	How long your accounts have been open	Keep your oldest card open.

Factor	What it measures	The fastest lever
New enquiries	How often you have recently applied for credit	Space applications out by 3-6 months.

Credit mix, explained properly

Credit mix is simply the variety of credit you manage well. A profile with only credit cards looks one-dimensional; a profile with a card plus one installment loan (a car loan, a consumer-durable EMI, or a gold loan) shows that you can handle both revolving credit and fixed EMIs. You do not need to borrow to build mix - but if you already have a mix, do not close the installment loan early just to 'simplify'.

What does NOT affect your CIBIL score

- Your salary, your savings, your investments or your bank balance.
- Your age, gender, religion or caste.
- Checking your own score or report (that is a soft enquiry).
- Whether you have a credit card at all - though no credit at all makes you invisible to lenders, which has its own cost (see Chapter 10).

The one rule that beats every trick

If you do nothing else, pay every EMI and every card bill on or before the due date. Payment history is the heaviest factor in the model. A single payment missed by more than 30 days can knock 50 to 100 points off your score and stays on your report for years.

Chapter 4

The 2026 reporting revolution: why your score moves in days now

Until recently, banks sent your data to the bureaus about once a month. In 2026, that changed - and it changes how you should time your repayments.

The RBI has steadily tightened how often lenders report your credit behaviour. Under the Master Direction of 6 January 2025, reporting moved to a fortnightly cycle (as on the 15th and the last day of each month). Then, by amendment directions issued on 4 December 2025 and effective from 1 July 2026, reporting moved again to a **weekly cycle**: lenders report your data as on the 9th, 16th, 23rd and the last day of each month.

Period	How often lenders reported	How fast a change showed up
Before 2025	Roughly monthly	Weeks to a month or more
From 1 January 2025	Fortnightly (15th and last day)	About two weeks
From 1 July 2026	Weekly (9th, 16th, 23rd, last day)	Often within a few days

Why this cuts both ways

Faster reporting rewards good behaviour sooner - clear a big card balance and it can show up within days, not weeks. But it punishes mistakes just as fast. A bounced EMI or a maxed-out card is now visible to the next lender almost immediately. The delay that used to give you a soft landing is gone.

The practical takeaway: your repayments and your balances are now a live signal. If you are about to apply for a loan, you can no longer assume last month's numbers are what the bank will see. They will see roughly this week's.

Your new reporting dates

Mark the 9th, 16th, 23rd and the last day of every month. These are the dates on which your card balance and loan status are captured. If you want a low balance to be the one recorded, pay it down a couple of days before each of these dates.

Chapter 5

The five score killers, and the exact fix for each

Almost every damaged score traces back to one of five behaviours. Here is how each one hurts you, and the precise fix.

Score killer	How it hits you	The fix
1. A missed or late payment	A DPD (days past due) entry - the heaviest, longest-lasting damage.	Switch every EMI and card to auto-pay; keep a buffer in the account; never let a due date pass by even one day.
2. High credit utilisation	Using most of your limit signals dependence on credit.	Pay card balances down before each reporting date (9th, 16th, 23rd, last day); keep under 30%, aim under 10%.
3. Settled or written-off status	A 'Settled' tag is penalised almost like a default and stays for years.	Always prefer full repayment marked 'Closed'. If already settled, get the closure letter and add new on-time activity.
4. Too many hard enquiries	Several applications in a short window look like desperation.	Space credit applications 3-6 months apart; use pre-approved offers; never 'apply everywhere to see'.
5. Closing your oldest card	Shortens your credit history and raises your utilisation ratio.	Keep old cards open with one small recurring spend per month.

How fast each fix moves the needle

- **Fastest (days to weeks):** fixing an incorrect entry via dispute, and dropping utilisation before a reporting date.
- **Medium (1-6 months):** re-establishing a clean payment record; adding a secured card; spacing out applications.
- **Slowest (12-36 months):** recovering from a settled, written-off or default entry, because the record itself stays visible for years even after the status improves.

Do not close cards to 'look tidy'

Closing an old credit card feels responsible. For your score it usually backfires: you lose the length of history and your utilisation ratio jumps because the same spending is now measured against a smaller total limit.

Chapter 6

Read your credit report line by line

You cannot fix what you cannot read. A credit report is dense, but it has only a handful of fields that matter, and a small set of errors that quietly cost people loans.

The fields that decide your fate

Field	What it means	What to watch for
DPD	Days Past Due - how many days late a payment was in a given month	Any DPD above 0 in a month you actually paid on time is an error.
Account status	Active, Closed, Settled, Written-off, Suit filed	'Settled' or 'Written-off' should be 'Closed' if you cleared the dues.
Overdue amount	Any amount still shown as unpaid	Should read zero on a settled or closed account.
Credit limit / High credit	Your limit and the most you have ever used	A limit shown too low inflates your utilisation.
Current balance	What you owe right now	Should match your latest statement.
Enquiry section	Who pulled your report and when	Look for enquiries you never authorised.

The errors that cost you the most

- **A closed loan still shown as active or unpaid.** Very common, and very damaging - it looks like an ongoing debt.
- **A wrong DPD entry.** A 'late' mark on a month you paid on time attacks the heaviest factor.
- **An account you do not recognise.** Could be a duplicate, a co-borrower's account, or identity misuse.
- **Duplicate accounts** from the same lender, inflating your apparent debt.
- **Wrong personal details** - a name spelling, PAN or address that does not match your KYC.

The 10-point audit

- 1 Confirm your name, PAN and date of birth are exactly right.
- 2 List every account - do you recognise all of them?
- 3 Check every 'Active' account: should any of them be 'Closed'?
- 4 Scan the DPD column for any month you actually paid on time.
- 5 Check the overdue amount is zero where it should be.
- 6 Confirm each account's status: Closed, Settled, Written-off, Suit filed.
- 7 Compare each current balance with your latest statement.
- 8 Read the enquiry list - any pull you did not authorise?
- 9 Check your credit limits are shown correctly.

- 10** Note the report date - you must dispute against a recent report (CIBIL accepts reports from the past 60 days).

Chapter 7

The dispute playbook: fix errors and get paid for delays

Raising a dispute is free, it is your right, and the RBI backs it with a compensation rule that most people have never heard of.

Step by step

- 1 Pull your latest report** from the bureau (or the lender's report) so you are disputing against a current document.
- 2 Identify the exact entry** - the account number, the field and the month. Vague disputes get rejected at intake.
- 3 Raise the dispute** through the bureau's dispute centre (for CIBIL, the Consumer Dispute Resolution section) or with the lender directly. It is free.
- 4 Track it.** You get a reference number; log in to follow the status.
- 5 Wait for the outcome.** The lender investigates and either confirms, corrects or deletes the entry.

The 30-day clock and the Rs. 100-a-day right

Under the RBI's framework for delayed updation or rectification of credit information, if your complaint is not resolved within **30 calendar days** from the date you first filed it, you are entitled to compensation of **Rs. 100 per calendar day** of delay. Internally, the lender gets 21 days and the bureau the remaining nine. The compensation must be credited to your account within five working days of resolution.

- This applies to **delays in resolving a dispute** - not to the score itself, and not to disputes already decided or pending in a court or consumer forum.
- Complaints purely about how your score is calculated are outside the compensation framework.
- If compensation is wrongly denied, you can escalate to the RBI under the Reserve Bank - Integrated Ombudsman Scheme.

Sweep all four bureaus

Fixing an error at one bureau does not fix it at the others. After any correction, pull your free report from each of the four bureaus and dispute the same error wherever it still appears. Lenders may read any of them.

Chapter 8

The utilisation timing hack

Credit utilisation is the second-heaviest factor, and it is the one you can move fastest - if you understand when your balance is measured.

Your utilisation is the percentage of your total credit limit that you are using. If you have one card with a Rs. 1 lakh limit and a balance of Rs. 80,000, your utilisation is 80%. Lenders read that as heavy reliance on credit, even if you pay in full every month.

The timing point that changes everything

The bureau does not record your balance on your payment due date - it records it on the **reporting date**. Since 1 July 2026 those dates are the 9th, 16th, 23rd and the last day of the month. So the number that reaches lenders is whatever your balance was on those days, not whatever it was on the day your bill was due.

- **If you pay after the reporting date:** the bureau sees the high balance, and your utilisation looks bad.
- **If you pay before the reporting date:** the bureau sees the low balance, and your utilisation looks healthy.

The target numbers

Situation	Aim for utilisation
Normal month	Under 30% of each card's limit
Rebuilding after damage	Under 15%
About to apply for a loan	Under 10%

Two quick levers

First, pay down before the reporting date rather than the due date. Second, ask your bank for a credit-limit increase - a higher limit with the same spending instantly lowers your utilisation ratio, and a limit increase does not by itself trigger a hard enquiry the way a new application does.

Chapter 9

Recovering from settled, written-off or default

These are the deepest wounds a credit report can carry. The recovery is real but slow, and the first thing to accept is that the entry does not vanish when you pay.

Status	What it means	Impact	How to improve it
Written-off	The lender gave up on the debt and booked it as a loss	Most negative	Repay in full; get the status updated; add new on-time activity.
Settled	You paid an agreed amount less than the full outstanding	Penalised almost like a default	Prefer full repayment marked 'Closed'; obtain the settlement letter; build fresh history.
Default / NPA	Payments overdue beyond 90 days	Severe and long-lasting	Clear dues, stop the bleeding, then rebuild with a secured card.

How long these entries stay visible

Negative entries such as settled, written-off or default records generally remain on an Indian credit report for up to **seven years** from the event (the settlement, write-off or default), according to the credit bureaus' published guidance. The status can be updated to 'Closed' once you have cleared the dues - which reduces the damage - but the record of the account itself stays visible for the retention period.

The realistic rebuild path

- 1 Obtain your No Dues Certificate or settlement letter and ask the lender to update the account status.
- 2 Add fresh, on-time activity: an FD-backed secured credit card or a small loan repaid on time for 12-18 months.
- 3 Keep every other payment perfect and your utilisation low.
- 4 Expect a meaningful recovery only after 18-36 months of consistent good behaviour, with the negative entry continuing to drag until it ages off.

No one can delete an accurate negative entry

If the entry is true, no agent, no fee and no 'repair' service can legally remove it. Anyone promising a guaranteed removal of accurate information is selling you a scam. The only legitimate route to a cleaner report is accurate data, corrected data, and time.

Chapter 10

First-time borrowers and thin files

If you have never borrowed, you have no score - and a lender reading a blank file is reading nothing. Here is how to fix that, and the rule that protects you.

The rule in your favour

The RBI's Credit Information Reporting Directions, 2025 state that **first-time borrowers' loan applications should not be rejected just because they have no credit history**. Lenders are expected to assess you using bank statements, income proof and other financial data. If a branch turns you away only for having 'no CIBIL history', you are entitled to point this out.

Why lenders still hesitate

From a lender's side, no history means no evidence of how you repay. They cannot see whether you are reliable, so they treat you as unknown risk. The fix is to give them evidence - deliberately and cheaply.

How to build a score from zero

- **A secured (FD-backed) credit card.** You deposit a fixed amount; the bank gives you a card against it. Use it lightly and pay in full - you build history with almost no risk.
- **A small consumer-durable or gold loan EMI.** One modest EMI product, repaid on time, proves you can service debt.
- **Become a co-applicant or guarantor carefully.** It can help, but if the primary borrower defaults it lands on your report too - so only for someone you trust.

- **Keep it simple.** One or two products used well beat five used badly. Do not open five cards at once; the enquiries alone will hurt you.

Do not 'avoid credit' to stay safe

Staying away from all credit feels prudent, but it leaves you with no file - and a blank file is its own kind of problem. Build a small, clean, well-managed credit history early. It is far easier to build a good score from scratch than to repair a bad one.

Chapter 11

Credit cards: how to use one without hurting your score

A credit card is the fastest way to build a score and the fastest way to wreck one. The difference is entirely in how you use it.

The interest-free period is a promise with conditions

If you pay the full statement amount by the due date, you pay no interest on purchases and you build a clean record. If you pay only the minimum due, you keep the card active but start paying interest - often 30-45% a year - on the balance, and your utilisation climbs. The minimum-due trap is the most expensive habit in personal finance: it protects you from a missed-payment mark but can cost more in interest than the purchase itself.

What to look for in a card

- **A fee you can justify.** Many cards are free for life; do not pay an annual fee for a card you will barely use.
- **A limit that gives you headroom.** A higher limit lowers your utilisation ratio for the same spending.
- **Rewards you will actually use** - not the headline offer on the leaflet.

Rules that keep you safe

- Pay the full amount, not the minimum.
- Never withdraw cash on a card - cash advances attract interest from day one and carry high fees.
- Remember that spending on an add-on card counts against the primary cardholder's limit and utilisation.
- Keep your oldest card open with one small recurring spend (a subscription or a phone bill).
- Set auto-pay for the full statement amount, not the minimum.

If your file is thin or damaged, start secured

A secured (FD-backed) credit card is the cleanest way back. You cannot overspend, the lender holds your deposit, and every on-time month adds a positive line to your report.

Chapter 12

What banks check beyond your score

A good score opens the door. It does not walk you through it. A 780 score can still be rejected if the rest of the picture does not add up.

Lenders run a full assessment, and the score is only the first filter. The factors below decide the rest.

Factor	What the lender is checking	How to improve it
FOIR	Fixed Obligation to Income Ratio - your EMIs as a share of income	Close or transfer high-EMI loans before applying.
Income stability	Steady income over time, not just this month	Avoid job changes right before applying; keep salary-account activity clean.
Employer / business profile	Employer category, or business vintage and ITRs	Self-employed: file ITRs and keep declared income consistent.
Banking behaviour	Bounces, ECS/NACH failures, low balances	Keep the salary account funded; never bounce an auto-debit.
Age and tenure	Remaining working years vs the loan tenure	A co-applicant or a shorter tenure can help.
The property (home loans)	Clear title, approvals, valuation	Do title and approval checks before you apply.

The RBI rules that protect you here

- **Lenders must tell you the specific reason** for a credit or loan rejection - a generic 'application not approved' is no longer compliant.
- **Loan-to-value caps on housing loans** limit how much of a property's value can be financed: broadly up to 90% for loans up to Rs. 20 lakh, 80% for loans above Rs. 20 lakh and up to Rs. 75 lakh, and 75% for loans above Rs. 75 lakh. These caps mean a bigger down payment is required as the property price rises.

A high score is necessary, not sufficient

Treat the score as your entry ticket and the FOIR and income stability as the interview. Prepare both before you apply, and you will not waste a hard enquiry on a rejection.

Chapter 13

How a lender actually decides

From the moment you submit an application to the moment you get a decision, your file passes through a short, mechanical pipeline. Knowing the stages tells you where you can still influence the outcome - and where you cannot.

Stage	What happens	What you can influence
Application	You submit KYC, income proof and the amount you want	The accuracy and completeness of your documents

Stage	What happens	What you can influence
Bureau pull	A hard enquiry; the lender reads your credit report	Nothing at this point - this is why you prepare first
Internal scoring	Bureau data plus income, FOIR, employer and age are scored	Nothing now - it was decided before you applied
Underwriting	A human or a rule engine checks policy, property and risk	Co-applicant, loan amount and tenure
Decision	Sanction or rejection, with a reason required by RBI	You can request the specific reason

What this tells you

- **Everything important happens before the bureau pull.** Your score, your report accuracy and your FOIR are all set in advance. The application itself is where you spend the preparation you have already done.
- **The pull costs you a little.** Each hard enquiry dips your score slightly, so you want one well-prepared application, not five hopeful ones.
- **A rejection is data, not a verdict.** Ask for the specific reason, fix that exact issue, and reapply once.

Prepare, then apply once

Fix the file, lower utilisation, sort out the FOIR and gather the documents - and only then let a lender pull your report. The people who apply once, prepared, get approved; the people who apply everywhere, hoping, do not.

Chapter 14

The FOIR maths, worked

The single most common reason a person with a good score is still rejected is FOIR. It takes five minutes to understand and it can save you a rejection.

FOIR - Fixed Obligation to Income Ratio - is all your fixed monthly obligations plus the new EMI, divided by your gross monthly income. Lenders typically cap it at about 40-50% for salaried borrowers, and sometimes higher for very high incomes. If adding the new EMI pushes you past the cap, the loan is declined regardless of your score.

Worked example 1 - the rejection

Income Rs. 75,000 a month. Existing car loan EMI Rs. 12,000, credit-card minimum Rs. 5,000. You apply for a home loan whose EMI would be Rs. 35,000.

Line	Amount
Gross monthly income	Rs. 75,000
Existing obligations	Rs. 17,000
Proposed new EMI	Rs. 35,000
Total obligations	Rs. 52,000

Line	Amount
FOIR	52,000 / 75,000 = 69.3% - above the cap, declined

Worked example 2 - the fix

Same income of Rs. 75,000. You first clear the credit-card balance (dropping the Rs. 5,000 minimum), and prepay part of the car loan so its EMI falls to Rs. 6,000. Now existing obligations are Rs. 6,000. With the same Rs. 35,000 proposed EMI, total obligations are Rs. 41,000 - a FOIR of 54.7%. Still tight, but a co-applicant's income or a longer tenure brings the EMI down and the application becomes viable.

Raise your eligibility before you apply

The levers are: clear or reduce existing EMIs, add a co-applicant with income, choose a longer tenure to lower the EMI, and increase your down payment. Doing these before you apply is what turns a rejection into an approval.

Chapter 15

Score bands: what you qualify for

Scores cluster into bands that behave very differently at the counter. Know your band before you walk in.

Score band	How lenders generally read it
800+	Premium borrower - best rates, easiest approvals
750-799	Safe approval zone - prime rates
700-749	Approval with conditions - higher rate, lower amount
650-699	Risky - NBFCs and secured products mostly
Below 650	Mostly rejected by banks; secured loans remain open

Typical lender thresholds (indicative)

Every lender sets its own cut-off, and these vary with the product and the applicant's overall profile. As a rough guide: PSU banks often start around 700 and offer best rates at 750+; private banks around 725-750; housing finance companies around 700-720; NBFCs around 650-700 for secured products; and some digital lenders work from 600-650 for small tickets at higher rates. Treat these as directional, not fixed.

What a lower score costs you

- A higher interest rate, which compounds over the life of the loan.
- A smaller sanctioned amount than your income alone would support.
- A demand for more security or a co-applicant.
- Outright rejection at the automatic screening stage, before a human ever sees your file.

Secured products ignore the score

If you need money now and your score is poor, secured products remain open: a gold loan and a loan against a fixed deposit generally do not depend on your credit score, because the lender holds your asset as cover. They are not a fix for a bad score, but they are a legitimate bridge while you repair it.

Chapter 16

The 90-day repair plan

Ninety days is enough to correct errors and visibly improve utilisation. It is not enough to erase years of damage - but it is enough to change what a lender sees next month.

Window	Do this
Days 1-7	Pull your free full report from each bureau. Run the 10-point audit in Chapter 6. Set auto-pay on every EMI and card. List every error.
Days 8-30	File disputes for every genuine error (free). Pay card balances down before each reporting date. Apply for no new credit at all. Start the dispute tracker.
Days 31-60	Keep utilisation under 10%. If your file is thin, add a secured card. Follow up on disputes; if 30 days pass without resolution, note your Rs. 100/day compensation claim.
Days 61-90	Verify corrections across all four bureaus. Re-check your report date. Prepare income and bank documents. Apply only to pre-qualified or pre-approved offers.

The rule for the whole 90 days

No new credit applications. Every hard enquiry you trigger during repair is working against you. The only exception is a pre-approved offer you actually intend to take.

Chapter 17

The 12-month rebuild plan for scores below 650

Below 650, the game changes: you are not correcting a report, you are rebuilding trust. That takes a year, and it takes patience.

Months	Objective
1-3	Stop all damage: perfect payments, utilisation under 10%, zero new applications, disputes filed for errors.
4-6	Add positive activity: a secured card or small EMI repaid on time; keep every other account clean.
7-9	Deepen the record: keep utilisation low, never miss a date, don't close old accounts, re-check all four bureaus.
10-12	Consolidate: a year of clean behaviour now shows on the report. Prepare documents and apply selectively.

Realistic expectations

Starting score	Typical time to reach 750
700 and above	2-4 months
650-699	4-8 months
600-649	6-12 months
Below 600	12 months and beyond

Honest expectation-setting

These timelines are directional and depend on your history. A genuine negative entry will keep dragging until it ages off, however well you behave now. The score improves as the negative entry's weight fades against your new, clean record - not because the old entry disappears.

Chapter 18

Comparing loan offers: the numbers that actually matter

Two lenders quoting the same headline rate can cost you very differently. Compare the whole package, not the sticker.

What to compare	Why it matters
All-in cost (APR)	Includes the rate plus fees - the true cost of borrowing.
Processing fee	Often 0.5-2% of the loan; sometimes negotiable.
Prepayment / foreclosure charge	Floating-rate home loans cannot carry a foreclosure penalty for individual borrowers; check other products.
Fixed vs floating	Fixed is predictable; floating is usually cheaper over time but moves with rates.
Bundled insurance	Sometimes sold as compulsory; check whether it is actually optional.
Tenure	A longer tenure lowers the EMI but raises the total interest you pay.

The tenure trade-off, worked

A Rs. 20 lakh loan at 12% costs about Rs. 3.91 lakh in total interest over 3 years (EMI roughly Rs. 66428 a month). Stretch the same loan to 5 years and the EMI drops to roughly Rs. 44488, but total interest rises to about Rs. 6.69 lakh. The lower EMI feels comfortable; the longer tenure quietly costs you more. (Illustrative calculation, not a quote.)

Ask for two documents before you sign

Ask for the APR in writing and for the amortisation schedule - the month-by-month table of what you owe. If a lender will not put the all-in cost in writing, that is your answer.

Chapter 19

Which debt to clear first

When you have several debts, the order in which you clear them changes both your total cost and your score. There are two classic strategies, and one credit-specific rule that most people miss.

Strategy	How it works	Best for
Avalanche	Clear the highest interest rate first	Saving the most money overall
Snowball	Clear the smallest balance first	Motivation and momentum
Credit rule	Clear maxed-out cards first	Moving your score fastest

The credit-specific rule

- If any card is above 30% utilisation, clear it first - dropping utilisation is one of the fastest score movers there is.
- As you clear an account, do not close it. Keep the old ones open with a small recurring spend.
- Never settle a debt you can repay in full - 'Closed' beats 'Settled' every time.

A worked example

Debt	Balance	Rate	Clear it
Credit card A (80% used)	Rs. 80,000	about 42%	First - highest rate and highest utilisation
Personal loan	Rs. 1,50,000	about 16%	Second - high rate, unsecured
Car loan	Rs. 3,00,000	about 9%	Last - secured, lowest rate

Where the two ideas agree

In this example the avalanche and the credit rule point the same way - the maxed-out card goes first. That is common: the debts that cost you the most interest are often the ones hurting your score the most too.

Chapter 20

Your score is a savings problem too

Most missed payments are not a discipline failure - they are a cash-flow failure. The score you want is often just a buffer away.

- **Build one month of expenses** in a separate account. It is the difference between a tight month and a DPD entry.
- **Automate every payment** so a busy week cannot cause a missed due date.
- **Keep a small cushion in the salary account** so an auto-debit never bounces on a low-balance day.
- **Time big spends after the reporting dates** (the 9th, 16th, 23rd and last day), not before them.

- **If your income is irregular**, keep a dedicated payment fund and top it up in the good months.

The buffer is cheaper than the bounce

A missed EMI costs far more than the money you saved by skipping it - interest, a bounce charge, a DPD entry and months of score repair. One month of cushion prevents all of it.

Chapter 21

Co-applicants, guarantors and joint loans

A second person on the application can be the difference between an approval and a rejection - or the reason you are refused. Understand which one before you sign.

- **A co-applicant's income is added to yours** for the FOIR calculation, which can raise the amount you qualify for.
- **But lenders assess the joint application on the weaker profile.** Adding a co-applicant with a poor score or a damaged file can sink an application that was otherwise fine.
- **A guarantor is legally liable.** If the borrower defaults, the guarantor can be pursued, and the loan shows on the guarantor's own credit report.
- **For home loans, a co-owner usually must be a co-applicant.** Plan ownership and the loan together.

When it helps, and when it hurts

Move	Likely effect
Add a spouse or parent with a clean file	Usually positive - more income, stronger profile.
Add a co-applicant with a low score	Often negative - the joint file inherits the risk.
Stand as guarantor for someone else	Risky - their default becomes your problem and your report entry.
Be added as a co-owner but not a borrower	Check carefully - ownership and liability should be decided together.

Protect your own file first

Every guarantee you give is a loan you may have to repay. Before you co-sign anything, ask what happens to your own credit if the other person stops paying. If you cannot afford that outcome, do not sign.

Chapter 22

Your rights as a borrower

The rules give you more power than most people use. Here is the short list of what you are entitled to - keep it, because it is the script you use when a lender or a bureau stonewalls you.

- **One free full credit report per bureau per year**, including your score.
- **An SMS or email alert when a lender accesses your report.**
- **An alert when a lender reports a default or a days-past-due entry against you.**
- **Dispute resolution within 30 days** - and Rs. 100 per calendar day in compensation if it slips beyond that.

- **A specific reason** for any loan or credit rejection - a generic refusal is not compliant.
- **First-time borrowers** cannot be rejected only for lacking a credit history.
- **Free dispute resolution** - you should never pay to correct an error on your report.
- **Escalation** to the Reserve Bank - Integrated Ombudsman Scheme if a complaint or compensation is not resolved.

On consent and your data

RBI has tightened how credit bureaus share your credit information with third parties. Where they share it on your consent, the rules require that it be used only for the agreed purpose and stored for a limited time. Be deliberate about who you let pull your report - and watch your access alerts for pulls you never authorised.

Chapter 23

Credit after a job loss or restructuring

A lost job or a restructured loan is not the end of your credit life. What matters far more is how you handle the account from here - because a manageable problem and a written-off entry look very different on a report.

- **Understand how a moratorium or restructuring will be reported.** If a lender gives you a payment holiday or extends the tenure, ask how the account will be coded on your report before you accept it.
- **Never go silent.** Silence turns a restructurable problem into a default. Talk to the lender early; most would rather reschedule than write off.
- **Protect the essentials.** If you can keep even one account in perfect standing, do - it anchors the recovery.
- **Resume and rebuild deliberately.** Once income returns, resume payments, get the status corrected, then add a small secured line to start fresh positive activity.

The cost of going silent

A default that could have been a restructuring becomes a written-off entry - the most negative status a report can carry - and stays visible for years. The conversation you avoid today is the rejection you face tomorrow.

Chapter 24

Credit for students, young earners and small business

Two groups are often told they cannot borrow, and both can. The route is different for each, but the lender is asking the same question.

Students and young earners

- An education loan builds a repayment record from the day the EMI starts - and a parent as co-applicant strengthens the application.
- Where a student card is available, use it lightly and pay in full; it is a low-risk way to open a file early.

- The habit that matters: one small account, used well, from a young age is worth more than a large one used badly.

Small business owners

- Lenders read your business credit through the **current account** and your **ITRs**, not only your personal score. Keep the account free of bounces and ECS/NACH failures.
- File your ITRs every year and keep declared income realistic - under-declaring shrinks the loan you can qualify for later.
- Maintain one secured and one unsecured line, both repaid on time, to show a healthy mix.
- Government-backed schemes for first-time business borrowers exist, but the behaviour on those loans is still reported to the bureaus - a subsidy is not a free pass.

The common thread

Student or business owner, the lender is asking one question: will this person repay, on time, every time? Your whole job is to hand them evidence of yes.

Chapter 25

Five real profiles, worked end to end

The rules make more sense on real people. Here are five situations you will recognise, and the exact sequence that fixes each.

Profile 1 - the fresher with no history

Age 23, first job, Rs. 45,000 a month, never borrowed. Wants a credit card and, in a year, a car loan.

- Applies for one secured or entry-level card; uses it for a small recurring spend; pays in full by the due date every month.
- Never exceeds 30% of the limit; never applies for a second card in the same quarter.
- After 12 months, has a genuine payment record - and qualifies for the car loan on income plus a clean file.

Profile 2 - the 640 score with one settled card

Age 31, settled a credit card two years ago, now earns Rs. 70,000. Keeps getting rejected.

- Obtains the settlement letter and asks the lender to update the status; disputes any wrong entry.
- Takes a small FD-backed secured card and uses it lightly for 12 months.
- Keeps utilisation under 10% and applies for nothing else.
- Realistic path: back to 700+ over roughly 8-12 months; the settled entry keeps a mild drag until it ages off.

Profile 3 - the 780 score rejected for a home loan

Age 36, strong score, Rs. 1 lakh a month, but already pays Rs. 45,000 in EMIs across a car loan, personal loan and cards.

- The score was never the problem - the FOIR was. Existing obligations plus the new EMI blew past the cap.
- Clears the credit-card balance, prepays the personal loan, and reduces the car-loan EMI.
- Adds a spouse as co-applicant and extends the tenure slightly.
- Re-applies once, with a FOIR inside the lender's cap - and is approved.

Profile 4 - the 690 score with maxed-out cards

Age 28, Rs. 60,000 a month, three cards all above 80% utilisation, always pays on time.

- Pays each card down below 30% before the reporting dates; then below 10% for two cycles.
- Requests limit increases on the two oldest cards.
- Stops using cards for discretionary spend for one quarter.
- The utilisation drop alone typically moves this profile into the 750 zone within a few reporting cycles.

Profile 5 - the self-employed borrower with no salary slip

Age 40, runs a small business, income varies, wants a business loan.

- Files ITRs consistently and keeps declared income realistic - under-declaring shrinks the loan he can get.
- Keeps the current account clean: no bounces, no ECS failures.
- Maintains one secured and one unsecured line, both repaid on time, to show a healthy mix.
- Applies with 2-3 years of ITRs and bank statements that match them.

The pattern across all five

None of these people needed a secret trick. They needed the right sequence: fix the file, lower utilisation, respect the FOIR, apply once, and let time do the rest.

Chapter 26

The habits of people who never worry about their score

There is no trick to a strong score. There is a set of boring habits, done consistently, that make the number take care of itself.

- 1 They automate every EMI and card payment, so nothing depends on memory.
- 2 They keep utilisation low almost by reflex - under 30%, often under 10%.
- 3 They apply for credit rarely and deliberately, not out of curiosity.
- 4 They pull their free credit report once a year and read it.
- 5 They never settle a debt they can close in full.
- 6 They keep their oldest account open.
- 7 They keep their phone number and email current, so the bureau's access alerts actually reach them.

The point is that it is not clever

A strong score is not a hack or a secret. It is the same handful of habits, repeated for years. Start them today and the number follows.

Chapter 27

Scams, myths and traps

The credit-repair market is full of promises that cannot legally be kept. Knowing the myths is as valuable as knowing the rules.

Myths that cost you money

Claim you will hear	The truth
"We can remove any negative entry for a fee."	No one can remove accurate information. Only errors can be corrected, and correcting them is free.
"Checking your score lowers it."	False. Your own check is a soft enquiry and has no effect.
"Settling a loan is as good as closing it."	False. 'Settled' is penalised almost like a default and stays visible for years.
"Your salary decides your score."	False. Income does not enter the score. Payment behaviour does.
"A guaranteed score boost in 7 days."	Only genuine error corrections and a utilisation drop move it that fast - and you can do both yourself, free.

Traps to avoid

- **Advance-fee 'repair' agents:** they take a fee, do nothing you could not do free, and sometimes vanish.
- **Fake loan apps:** apps that ask for an upfront fee or excessive permissions before 'approving' a loan.
- **Sharing your PAN, OTP or Aadhaar** with anyone promising a score fix - that is how identity fraud starts.
- **Multiple simultaneous applications** across many lenders, which is exactly what makes your profile look risky.

Use the alert built into the system

RBI requires credit bureaus to send you an SMS or email alert when your credit report is accessed by a lender, and lenders to alert you when they report a default or a days-past-due entry. Keep your mobile number and email updated with your bank and the bureaus, and read those alerts - they are your early-warning system against unauthorised enquiries and identity misuse.

Chapter 28

Questions people ask most

How often is my score updated?

Your score changes only when new credit activity reaches the bureau. Since 1 July 2026 lenders report as on the 9th, 16th, 23rd and last day of the month, so a change can appear within days of a repayment or a new balance - but the score does not move on every update.

Does checking my own score lower it?

No. Checking your own score or report is a soft enquiry and has no effect at all. Only a lender's hard enquiry, when you apply for credit, can dip it slightly and temporarily.

How many free reports do I get?

One free full credit report, including your score, per bureau per calendar year - so up to four if you use all four bureaus. Separately, partner apps show a free score refreshed roughly monthly.

Can I improve my score in a week?

Only two things move it that fast: correcting an error on your report, and dropping your credit-card utilisation before a reporting date. Everything else takes months.

Is a settled account worse than a written-off one?

No - written-off is generally the most negative, settled is next. Both are worse than a closed account. If you can repay in full, always prefer 'Closed' over 'Settled'.

Will paying off a loan immediately remove it from my report?

No. The account record stays visible, generally for up to seven years. The status updates to 'Closed', which reduces the damage, but the history remains.

Can a bank reject me even with a 780 score?

Yes. A high score passes the first filter, but the lender still checks FOIR, income stability, employer profile, banking behaviour and, for home loans, the property. A 780 score with a 70% FOIR is still a rejection.

Does my salary affect my score?

No. Income is not part of the score. It affects the loan amount you are eligible for, not the number itself.

What is a good utilisation level?

Under 30% of each card's limit in normal months, under 10% before you apply for a loan. Paying down before the reporting date is what makes it count.

Is it bad to have no credit history?

It is a problem, not an advantage. With no file, a lender cannot judge your reliability. RBI says first-time borrowers cannot be rejected only for having no history, but the practical fix is to build a small, clean record.

How long does a default stay on my report?

Generally up to seven years from the event, across the bureaus. The status can be updated once you clear the dues, but the record remains visible for the retention period.

Do all four bureaus show the same thing?

Not always. Lenders report to different bureaus, so a closed loan can look active at one and closed at another. Always check more than one before a major loan.

What is the Rs. 100-a-day compensation?

If a dispute you file is not resolved within 30 calendar days, you are entitled to Rs. 100 per calendar day of delay under RBI's framework. It applies to delays in resolving a dispute, not to the score or to complaints already pending elsewhere.

Can I dispute a genuine late payment?

No. If the late payment is real, it stays. You can only dispute information that is inaccurate or incomplete - not information you dislike.

Should I close my oldest credit card?

Usually no. Closing it shortens your credit history and raises your utilisation ratio. Keep it open with one small recurring spend.

Does applying for many loans at once hurt me?

Yes. Each application triggers a hard enquiry. A cluster of them looks like desperation. Space applications out by 3-6 months.

What is FOIR and what is a safe level?

FOIR is your total monthly EMIs as a share of gross income. Lenders typically cap it around 40-50% for salaried borrowers. Keep it below the cap after adding the new EMI.

Can a co-applicant's bad score hurt my application?

Yes. Lenders assess a joint application on the weaker profile, so a co-applicant with a poor score can sink it. Choose co-applicants with clean files.

Are 'credit repair' companies worth it?

No. Anything they can legally do, you can do yourself for free. Anyone promising to remove accurate negative information is selling something that cannot be delivered.

How do I know if my report has an unauthorised enquiry?

Read the enquiry section of your report and cross-check it with the SMS or email alerts the bureau must send you when a lender accesses your report. Dispute anything you did not authorise.

Does a credit card help or hurt my score?

It helps if you pay in full and keep utilisation low; it hurts if you carry a balance or max it out. The card is neutral - the behaviour decides.

What is a secured credit card?

A card backed by a fixed deposit you place with the bank. You cannot overspend, the lender is protected, and every on-time month builds your history. It is the standard first step for a thin or damaged file.

Do secured loans need a good score?

Generally no. Gold loans and loans against a fixed deposit are secured by your asset, so lenders rely less on your score. They are a legitimate bridge while you repair your file.

How do I escalate if my dispute is ignored?

After the 30-day window, claim your compensation, then escalate to the lender's grievance channel and, if needed, to the RBI under the Reserve Bank - Integrated Ombudsman Scheme.

Is my score the same at every bureau?

The concept is the same - a number from 300 to 900 - but the exact figure can differ because each bureau holds slightly different data. Lenders use whichever bureau they subscribe to.

Is a secured credit card worth it?

Yes, for a thin or damaged file. It is the safest way to open or reopen a payment history because you cannot overspend - the bank holds your deposit.

Do I need to pay to check my score?

No. You get one free full report per bureau per year, and many apps show a free score. Paying for a basic score check is rarely necessary.

What if my name is misspelt on my report?

Dispute it. A mismatch in your name, PAN or address is a common cause of failed identity matching and can hold up loan processing.

Can I have a good score with a low income?

Yes. The score reflects how you repay, not how much you earn. A modest, well-managed credit line can produce a strong score.

How long does a dispute take?

Simple profile corrections often resolve in a week or two; account-level disputes usually take the full 30 days because the lender has to investigate.

Should I take a loan just to build my score?

No. Do not borrow money you do not need purely for a score. If you want to build history, a secured card or a small EMI on something you already need is the sane route.

What is the difference between CIBIL and a credit bureau?

CIBIL is one bureau - TransUnion CIBIL. There are three others: Experian, Equifax and CRIF High Mark. Together they are the credit information companies.

Does a personal loan hurt my score?

Not by itself. A personal loan repaid on time helps your mix and history. It hurts only if you miss payments or use it to pile on more debt.

Chapter 29

Worksheets, templates and trackers

Print these or copy them into a notes file. A repair plan you can see is a repair plan you finish.

A. Credit report audit checklist

#	Check	Done
1	Name, PAN, DOB exactly correct	☐
2	Every account recognised	☐
3	Active accounts that should be Closed	☐
4	DPD errors in months you paid on time	☐
5	Overdue amounts that should be zero	☐
6	Status correct (Closed / Settled / Written-off)	☐
7	Balances match latest statements	☐
8	No unauthorised enquiries	☐
9	Credit limits shown correctly	☐
10	Report is recent (within 60 days)	☐

B. Dispute tracker

Bureau	Entry disputed	Date filed	Ref no.	Resolved by	Status
CIBIL					
Experian					
Equifax					
CRIF High Mark					

C. Monthly credit hygiene checklist

- All EMIs and card bills set to auto-pay, with a buffer in the account.
- Card balances paid down before the 9th, 16th, 23rd and last day.
- Utilisation under 30% on every card (under 10% before a loan).
- No new credit applications unless pre-approved and intended.
- Oldest credit card still open.
- Mobile number and email current with your bank and bureaus.

D. Loan-readiness checklist (before you apply)

- Score checked recently and in your target band.
- FOIR calculated and within the lender's cap.
- Existing high-EMI loans cleared or transferred.
- Income documents, bank statements and ITRs ready.
- Property title and approvals checked (for home loans).
- Applying to a pre-qualified offer, not everywhere at once.

E. Dispute message template

Use this wording when raising a dispute with a bureau or a lender. Keep it specific - vague disputes are rejected at intake.

Template

Subject: Dispute of incorrect information on my credit report. My name is [NAME], PAN [PAN], and my report reference is [REFERENCE / DATE]. The following entry is incorrect: [LENDER NAME], account number [ACCOUNT NUMBER]. The report shows [WRONG DETAIL - e.g. status 'Active' / a DPD of 30 for March 2026]. This is incorrect because [FACT - e.g. the loan was closed on 12 August 2025 and I hold the No Dues Certificate dated 15 August 2025]. I request that this entry be corrected. Please confirm the correction and, if the matter is not resolved within 30 calendar days, note that I will claim the compensation of Rs. 100 per calendar day provided under the RBI framework. Please acknowledge this dispute with a reference number.

F. The 30-day quick-start calendar

Days	Action
1-3	Pull your free report from every bureau. Run the 10-point audit. Note every error.
4-7	Set auto-pay on every EMI and card. Pay card balances down before the next reporting date.
8-14	File disputes for every genuine error. Start the dispute tracker.
15-21	Check the first dispute updates. Keep utilisation under 10%. Apply for nothing new.
22-30	Re-check the report. Note any dispute past 30 days for a Rs. 100/day claim. Prepare loan documents.

Chapter 30

Quick reference, contacts and glossary

The rules, dates and numbers - on one page.

Item	The position in 2026
Score range	300 to 900 (higher is better)
Free full report	One per bureau per calendar year, including score
Bureaus	TransUnion CIBIL, Experian, Equifax, CRIF High Mark
Reporting cycle	Weekly from 1 July 2026 (9th, 16th, 23rd, last day)
Dispute resolution	Within 30 days (lender 21 days, bureau 9 days)
Compensation for delay	Rs. 100 per calendar day beyond 30 days
Compensation payout	Within 5 working days of resolution
Access alerts	SMS/email when a lender accesses your report
First-time borrowers	Cannot be rejected only for having no credit history
Rejection reason	Lenders must state the specific reason
Negative entry retention	Generally up to 7 years from the event

Where to act

- **Get your free report:** each bureau's homepage has the free full credit report link.
- **Raise a dispute:** the bureau's dispute centre (CIBIL's is 'Consumer Dispute Resolution'); it is free.
- **Escalate:** the Reserve Bank - Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, if a complaint or compensation is not resolved.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
CIC / bureau	Credit Information Company - the four RBI-licensed credit bureaus
CIR	Credit Information Report - your full credit file
FFCR	Free Full Credit Report - your yearly free report, with score
DPD	Days Past Due - how late a payment was in a given month
FOIR	Fixed Obligation to Income Ratio - your EMIs as a share of income
LTV	Loan-to-Value - the share of a property's value a lender will finance
NPA	Non-Performing Asset - a loan overdue beyond 90 days
Soft / hard enquiry	Your own check (no effect) vs a lender's pull (slight, temporary effect)

One sentence to remember

Pay every bill on time, keep your utilisation low, correct your errors for free, and never pay anyone to do what the law already lets you do yourself.

Chapter 31

The one-page action plan and tracker

Everything in this playbook, compressed into the actions that matter - plus a tracker to keep you honest over twelve months.

The action plan

When	Do this
This week	Pull your free report from every bureau. Set auto-pay on every EMI and card. List every error.
This month	File disputes for genuine errors. Pay card balances down before each reporting date. Apply for nothing new.
Next 90 days	Keep utilisation under 10%. Verify corrections across all four bureaus. Prepare income and bank documents.
Before you apply	Check your FOIR. Gather documents. Apply once, to a pre-qualified offer - not everywhere.
Always	Pay on time, keep utilisation low, keep old accounts open, read your access alerts.

The 12-month tracker

Month	Score	Utilisation	Disputes open	New applications	Notes
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					

Use it honestly

Fill the tracker in every month, even when nothing has changed. Seeing a flat line is what pushes you to act - and watching utilisation fall and the score climb is what keeps you going.

Sources

Reserve Bank of India - Master Direction: Credit Information Reporting Directions, 2025 (6 January 2025). RBI - Credit Information Companies Directions, 2025 (28 November 2025, updated 1 July 2026). RBI - amendment directions on reporting frequency (4 December 2025). RBI - framework for compensation for delayed updation/rectification of credit information (26 October 2023, effective 26 April 2024). RBI - Reserve Bank Integrated Ombudsman Scheme. TransUnion CIBIL Consumer Dispute Resolution. CRIF High Mark published guidance. Paisabazaar published guidance on the 2026 reporting rules. Reported coverage: The Times of India, Moneycontrol, Outlook Money, Mint, The Economic Times and The Hindu BusinessLine.